long way, to before the war when JFK stayed in London. Their friendship was both personal and professional. When Ormsby-Gore became Minister of State at the Foreign Office in 1954, he provided wise counsel to his friend on the test ban negotiations and other foreign policy issues. Kennedy considered that next to McGeorge Bundy, Ormsby-Gore was the cleverest man he knew. When the post of UK ambassador to Washington became available, Kennedy lobbied Macmillan for his friend (and distant relative) to get the job. Macmillan recognised the benefits of having a special relationship within the special relationship and was happy to oblige. 'I trust David as I would trust my own cabinet,' JFK remarked.[57] Unlike members of his cabinet, however, he would invite him on weekend trips to Cape Cod, Hyannis Port, and Palm Beach. How much Ormsby-Gore knew of JFK's insatiable sexual appetite is unknown. An intriguing postscript to their relationship was that Ormsby-Gore (unsuccessfully) proposed marriage to Jacqueline Kennedy several years after the president's death.

Shortly before the first meeting with his advisers on 16 October, Kennedy confronted his daughter, Caroline, in the Oval Office. He demanded to know if she had been eating candy. 'Yes, no, or maybe?' he asked. Structuring the exchange in this way gave him an answer, while displaying sensitivity to his daughter's situation. He adopted a similar approach with Ormsby-Gore. After explaining the discovery of the missiles, he did not ask Ormsby-Gore for his view on how to react. He told him his government had decided there was a choice between 'an air strike on Monday morning' or a blockade. Which would Ormsby-Gore choose? Any other ambassador would surely have consulted his government. Ormsby-Gore's presence in the White House, however, was not simply down to his diplomatic role. Unsurprisingly, he did not choose the air strike. He also made clear some of the problems with a blockade. Kennedy then mentioned the possibility of an invasion (which the ambassador said was 'most unwise' at this time) or doing nothing, which the President thought 'not only politically impossible but was in any case too dangerous.'[58]

Of the two alternatives, Ormsby-Gore favoured the blockade, but suggested 'this would have far reaching political implications including the probability of a major Russian reaction perhaps in the Berlin context'.[59]